

Froogle is gone

Google has rechristened Froogle to "Google Product Search". Froogle.com now points to www.google.com/products, and it looks like they're putting in a bigger effort to make this for products what Google is to Web search. It's still completely US-biased, but it still serves as a good price indicator for stuff you want to buy.



Feisty Fawn Released

Ubuntu's latest version, Feisty Fawn, was released last month. So many users were downloading, it was akin to all of Ubuntu's 160 mirrors being DDoS-ed. Hooray for the Torrent network though—some caring souls sat, downloaded it at pathetic speeds, and then promptly seeded it for us.



Enter

Abhijeet Sawant Singer

Sawant shot to fame by winning the Indian Idol contest. He soon released his first album, *Aapka Abhijeet Sawant*, which became a hit. Then on, there has been no turning back for the singer.

Technology to you is...

An important aspect of life. I am a singer, and it is used extensively in my field. Thanks to technology, editing, mixing, and retakes can be done in a very short period of time. Technology has now become the fourth element of life!

What gadgets do you use?

I have a wonderful audio system, an Xbox, a Nokia N73, a Sony handycam, a 7-megapixel Sony Cybershot, and a Sony Vaio notebook.

What would your dream gadget be?

I wish I had a bike or scooter that could fly...

What do you mostly do online?

I check my mail, hunt for good music Web sites, socialise on Orkut, and check for games online. If time permits, I respond to fan mail.

Any instance where technology has really helped you?

A year ago, my friend met with an accident at 3 AM. Thanks to the mobile, we were able to reach a helpline. As I said earlier, technology has now become a part of us. We cannot ignore it.

WORLD DOMINATION

Microsoft Targets The Poor

No, this is not another anti-piracy story, so stop smirking! Recently, Microsoft executives were all abuzz about their latest plan to target the 5 billion users who aren't already using PCs. With a global population of over six billion people, Microsoft is appalled that only under a billion use its products—including pirated software users. In a bid to make this a more Microsoft-dependent world (and thus, World Domination), the company is looking to make deals with governments to provide cheaper versions of its popular software for students and the underprivileged.

When you think about it, of all the software that Microsoft makes, two really stand out: the world's most popular OS, Windows XP, and the world's most used office suite, Microsoft Office. While most of us *privileged* users might have to spend several months' salaries to afford these software, there are entire villages in India that simply cannot afford them. The world (a lot of *Digit* readers included) has been crying out for Microsoft to consider that their software costs as much as five times the hardware that it runs on, and it seems Bill Gates finally listened.

The offer? How does \$3 (a mere Rs 135) sound as a

price tag for Windows XP Starter Edition, Microsoft Office Home and Student 2007, Microsoft Math 3.0, Learning Essentials 2.0 for MS Office and Windows Live

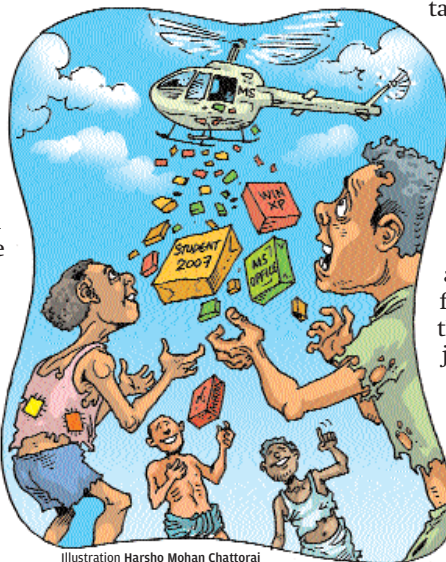


Illustration Harsho Mohan Chatteraj

Mail Desktop? Unbelievable? Believe it! Termed the Student Innovation Suite, Gates unveiled Microsoft's plans during a speech in China in mid-April. Although the Microsoft Student Innovation Suite (MSIS) is meant for students, it doesn't apply only to schools and colleges—students can use this at home, and Microsoft knows that the entire family will probably use the same PC.

So is Microsoft selling all these great products for \$3 to everyone? Not on your life, as always, there's a catch. Remember, the software is being sold to governments, not the students themselves.

And this is supplemented by the provision that the governments have to pay at least 50 per cent of the price of the PC that MSIS is bundled with. Since this is targeted at the underprivileged, Microsoft even accepts the purchase of refurbished PCs as eligible for MSIS.

In terms of India, this means that our government now has the power to provide students and underprivileged families with PCs for half the hardware price and just \$3 for the software. Now if only we had plans for such a project in place, we could really see a spurt in the amount of PC users in India. It would also help cut down the amount of pirated

versions of Microsoft software being used in India.

So what's in it for Microsoft? Well, Microsoft does do a lot of charity work, as does Bill Gates, and this is their way of giving back to society. OK fine, we didn't buy that either. It's obvious that one more billion people depending on Microsoft products will result in a lot more business sales because employees are already versed with Microsoft. However, one can't blame Microsoft, it is after all a company that has to do business. For underprivileged Indian end-users, however, it's a win-win situation.